Ancient Nationalism: How Roman Leaders Used Material Culture and the Past to Consolidate and Hold Power.

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Roman emperors and leaders were renowned for their ambition and grandiosity, not only in their rise to power but in how they legitimized and preserved it. Less understood, however, is how their mindfulness and manipulation of the past bolstered their authority and shaped their imposing characters. It is essential to not only the ancient historian, but to all readers, to make this subject common knowledge because of its similarities or parallels to contemporary leaders' use of the past in the political sphere. Through a case study of Roman leaders like Constantine the Great and Pompey the Great this paper will explore ancient primary sources like coinage, literature, and statuary along with secondary scholarship to analyze how Roman leaders used material culture for authority. This study argues that the strategic use of history, statuary, and monuments was not only a tactic used for individual promotion but an essential tool, allowing Roman leaders to claim supremacy and legitimacy from the Roman Republic to the Byzantine Empire.

Historiography

Roman Emperors utilized the past to consolidate and display their power, from the Romans of the Republic to the Byzantine Empire. Through antiquities and memory, these leaders displayed themselves as the contemporary version of previous great leaders, or as greater than those who came directly before them, whether Roman or from diverse cultures. Sarah Bassett, mentioned below, writes about the importance of antiquities and material culture in the Roman world. “Sculpture was the great medium of visual communication in the Greco-Roman world. In the choice of subject matter for individual statues and the juxtaposition of images to create visual narratives, cities documented their histories and in so doing legitimized their claims to status

within the territories of the Roman world by documenting their ties to the past."[1] This utilization of the past translated to the capital of Constantinople as well, as it was considered the "New Rome."[2] Paroma Chatterjee, cited below, also mentions the importance of statuary and material culture in her text. "Among the various kinds of mimesis put on display, statues reign supreme in that they, rather than any other media, come closest to resembling the divine. Additionally, statues signify permanence and power."[3] Again, both authors lay valuable groundwork for the intents and purposes of this historical survey. Roman leaders utilized material culture in an intentional way and were aware of the political and social benefits to such grandiose actions. The articles examined here offer scholarship on Roman leaders and their processes to use antiquity and memory to consolidate, gain, and display their power. This historiography presents scholarship, previous and contemporary, to not only highlight the topic at hand, but to display the material and textual source's progression and work in tandem with one another.

Sarah Bassett, now a professor Emeriti at the University of Indiana Bloomington, has done research on early medieval and Byzantine aesthetics and is the author of the first text examined, The Urban Image of Late Antique Constantinople. This text provides insight into how Constantine the Great knowingly used the past and shows the use of material culture with intent. Her scholarship surrounding the antiquities within the Hippodrome laid the foundation for a comprehensive study of Roman Emperors utilizing the past. While material culture is an important part of the text, Bassett also highlights the city of Constantinople itself, rather than just the objects within the city. The city encapsulated everything Constantine wanted, providing a

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[1] Bassett, Sarah. *The urban image of late antique Constantinople*. Cambridge, U.K: Cambridge University Press, 2006. 46-47.
[2] Bassett, Sarah Guberti. "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 45 (1991): 87–96. https://doi.org/10.2307/1291694. 94.
[3] Chatterjee, Paroma. *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture: Statues in Constantinople, 4th-13th Centuries CE*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022. 130.

visual language that represented Constantinople as the "New Rome." The continued discussion of statuary throughout the book enables scholars and readers to understand why these antiquities were important in a general sense and their own individual rights. Overall, the text provides a durable foundation for fostering an understanding of how Roman Emperors used statuary and antiquity to consolidate and display their power using the city of Constantinople as an example but providing case studies of sites like the Hippodrome, the Baths of Zeuxippos, and more. Bassett's book provides phenomenal analysis of the city of Constantinople and Constantine's use of material culture within his ideal city. The book lays a great foundation for the other secondary sources that argue for the intentional use of material culture by Roman leaders.

"The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture," by Mario Erasmo continues the work using Pompey the Great as a case study to understand further how Roman leaders utilized the past. Erasmo is a professor at the University of Georgia in their classics department and a cultural historian. Erasmo's background as a cultural historian is well displayed within his text as he quickly states his purpose that aligns with his interest. "This article examines the physical and figurative implementations of Pompey's self-representation as Alexander the Great and Agamemnon through his manipulation of text and architecture at the opening of his theatre."[4] Erasmo's analysis of Pompey provides insight into Roman Emperors and their use of the past at an earlier date in a historical sense but pushes Bassett's foundation by including a more in- depth look at architecture and text. Erasmo's utilization of text provides insight to his contribution to the overall study of the topic, as text (during the ancient period) was not mentioned in the same fashion within Bassett's article.[5] Erasmo's organization of the text

[4] Erasmo, Mario. "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." *Memoirs of the American Academy in Rome* 65 (2020): 43–69. https://doi.org/10.2307/27031294. 43.
[5] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 47.

allows for a seamless transition between introduction and analysis, providing subsections like "The Preformed Triumph" and "Setting the Stage." These sections allow Erasmo to methodologically progress through Pompey's actions in his theatre and continually provide analysis of every aspect of the theatre and its performances/actors. Erasmo pushes scholarship by acknowledging the complexities and the longevity of the allusions to previous great leaders that Pompey provides by asking questions about the relationship between the reenactor and Pompey, the audience and Pompey, and the reenactor and the audience.[6] Erasmo's utilization of the contemporary Roman theatre and the actors/relationships within the space is essential to expanding the scholarship on how Emperors displayed power, claiming that the space of Pompey's theatre itself holds the same, at the very least similar, value of victory and imperial power as grand statues.[7] Erasmo's examination of Pompey through text, architecture, and dramatized reenactments of his successes, all provide insight to how Roman leaders' use of the past was not strictly physical in the sense of statuary and antiquities. Erasmo does a phenomenal job at expanding the scholarship on Roman leaders and their use of the past and analysis of the different formats in which they did, while recognizing the complexities all in the same breath. While Erasmo's analysis of these relationships is honorable, and either way pushes forward the scholarship on the matter, one must question the reality of the period. How many Roman citizens were aware of this complex, three-pronged relationship? How many were simply there to enjoy the celebration and sit in awe of the theatrics? This may be a permanent historical gap, but the solution could be buried within primary/secondary sources that focus on the individual Roman citizen's experience.

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[6] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 64-65.
[7] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 67.

The final text examined comes out just a year after Erasmo's text and brings all three texts together in tandem with continued scholarship on Roman Emperors and their complex utilization of the past. *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture* by Paroma Chatterjee provides significant insight to the subject matter toward the latter end of the Roman Empire and utilizes statuary, art, architecture, and material culture to analyze the complex relationship between Roman Emperors and the past. Chatterjee, an associate professor of Art History at the University of Michigan, lets her interests be shown deeply within her book. Chatterjee pushes the scholarship in a different manner than the other two yet draws on similarities between the previous sources. Each author has a significant and individual way of analyzing material culture and displaying their cultural relevance, often tied to Roman Emperors' leadership, and continued show of power. However, she does utilize primary sources and case studies to her advantage when describing the complexities of the relationship between statuary and these Roman Emperors, their communities, and their cities. "But more importantly, this study is not interested in statues as a category unto itself. Instead, it seeks to unearth the varied physical and conceptual entanglements evident between statues and other kinds of images (mentioned above) in the late antique and medieval eras."[8] Chatterjee's expertise throughout the book is more aligned with analysis of antiquity, statuary, and art history rather than concise case studies of emperor's utilization of material culture to consolidate and display power. The scholarship emphasizes the importance of statuary and material culture in a deeper manner than the other texts and through a different lens (the lens being art history.) Chatterjee's utilization of material culture outside of statuary and architecture displays how the scholarship consistently progresses. Chatterjee states her purpose as "This book tracks the perceptions and associations

[8] Chatterjee, *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture.* 8.

invested in statues well into the medieval period. The word "statue" here sustains a broad referential frame. The book gestures to that object (sculpture in the round and in relief) both in its generic and sometimes specific capacities, and to exemplars usually located in Constantinople, but also in other places depending on the context/ source at hand."[9] Chatterjee here is highlighting how she plans to expand the subject matter and does so significantly throughout the text. Throughout the text, her tracking of the perceptions and associations in statues is well done, providing ample primary sources to display the school of thought at the time, but also displaying a knowledgeable perception of the field with constant citations of other contemporary authors. For example, Chatterjee goes on to mention Bassett's scholarship on the subject, "Sarah Bassett's book is the most comprehensive investigation to date of the statues that once stood in Constantinople along with its other monuments."[10] The text also provides analysis of the eagle and the snake, which Bassett does in her text, while Chatterjee utilizes Bassett, she refines or changes the original organization Bassett provides by not utilizing modern categorization.[11] The sources utilize constant similar antiquities and statuary, even when discussing different emperors and time periods. Chatterjee's book does a respectable job at accomplishing the goal she set out for, but the text at times is unclear. The text constantly flips from source to statuary/object and complex themes are often intertwined within the foundations of information laid about the statuary or the source. This critique is minimal, as her text is the most recent and the most researched out of the sources provided within the historiography.

Chatterjee, Erasmo, and Bassett are all significant sources that provide specific and essential information surrounding the importance of statuary and material culture to Roman

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[9] Chatterjee, Between *the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture.* 5.
[10] Chatterjee, *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture.* 18.
[11] Chatterjee, Between *the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture.* 5.

Emperors and how these aspects of material culture interacted with society. Even if each author did not cite the exact sources used within this historiography, they are collaborators on the subject at hand. Not only does each author provide excellent scholarship, but they also further push the study of the overarching material culture and its political usage in the ancient world in an arresting way. However, with issues like fully considering an ancient audience, questionable primary sources, and at times, a gap of knowledge between what emperors brought these antiquities, there is room for more scholarly study on the subject. The research intended for the paper to follow is an attempt to focus on individual emperors through primary and secondary sources while also attempting to fill the gap of intention and the audience's recognition of that intention.[12] While this historiography only reflects some of the scholarship within the broader historical field, these are questions and issues that deserve to be explored regardless. The first Roman leader examined in this survey is Pompey the Great.

Pompey the Great

Pompey the Great, a Roman general and statesman, is the earliest Roman example within the parameters of the paper. Pompey's success as a general largely allowed for the opening of his theatre in 55 B.C.E.[13] (Figure 1.) Pompey's theatre was the first permanent theatre built in Rome and where Julius Caesar was later assassinated. The success, however, was twofold; that success was displayed through the built environment of the theatre itself as well as the spectacles held within. The theatre itself was grand and unconventional as the architects were able to place the theatre on a flat and marsh-like plain rather than the prototypical sloping hill.[14] The theatre was

[12] Audience referring to the Roman people, citizens, and authors alike.
[13] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 44.
[14] Gagliardo, Maria C., and James E. Packer. "A New Look at Pompey's Theater: History, Documentation, and Recent Excavation." *American Journal of Archaeology* 110, no. 1 (2006): 93–122. http://www.jstor.org/stable/40026361. 93.

full of statuary and shrines to Roman gods like Honor, Victory, Virtue, and luck as well as a statue of Pompey the Great himself which was placed in front of the *Curia Pompeia* serving as a protector of the senate's new meeting hall.[15][16] The built environment, referring to the theatre itself, holds the same grandiose weight as the spectacles in the theatre and as Pompey himself. "The theatre included a landscaped portico that included the display of manubial spoils of a Hellenized Asia and commissioned contemporary artwork; representations of the nations conquered by Pompey."[17] The manubial spoils which Erasmo mentions provide evidence through the lens of the built environment.[18] This spolia is representative of conquered nations, their very presence serving as a continuous victory monument, specifically linked to Pompey. Spolia has an incredible impact within the Roman empire, for Pompey and those who follow him. "Spolia had the potential for enormous symbolic import. To begin with, spoils explained the riches of a conquered nation better than any possible description, thereby offering tangible proof that a campaign had been worth the undertaking. Even more important, however, was the very act of possession: ownership demonstrated domination."[19] Bassett's point that ownership demonstrates domination, is a common theme within the survey of this paper, both Pompey and Constantine are aware of their ownership and what it signified.

While the built environment and material culture's importance cannot be ignored, the plays staged within the theatre intertwine with the built environment and material culture. Simply, the theatre provides a space representative of Pompey's success. The plays hosted

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[15] Gagliardo, Packer. "A New Look at Pompey's Theater: History, Documentation, and Recent Excavation." 95.
[16] The *Curia Pompeia* or the Curia of Pompey was a designated structure for senate meetings. The curia itself was located at the entrance of Pompey's theatre.
[17] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 44.
[18] Manubial refers to the spoils of war, specifically under the context of the Roman empire.
[19] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople, 47.*

during the opening of the theatre were restaged versions of Accius' *Clytemnestra* and either Livius Andronicus' or Naevius' *Trojan Horse*.[20] Roman authors and historians, like Cicero, during Pompey's reign mention these plays within his texts and are referenced below. Cicero provides more context of the plays and captives, spoils, and reactions of the Roman crowd. The plays serve as a spectacle to Pompey's accomplishments and conquering of other nations, which provide connection to this triumph to a disconnected Roman audience, considering their absence from the actual battle. "The staging of a "performed" triumph in the theatre (within a restaged play) fulfills two functions: it alludes to Pompey's triple triumph, celebrated in 61 BCE, but it also functions as a restaged version of his triumph."[21] Again, the staging of Pompey's triumph is represented through the plays presented at the opening of his theatre, hence the use of the word performed. This spectacle was twofold as well; the plays themselves, and the presentation of captives and spoils, which both represented the full conquering of these other nations. Each individual portion of the spectacle is representative of Pompey's greatness and creates the opportunity for Pompey to be alluded to and compared to other great leaders of the past. Through the presentation of the plays, the captives, and the spoils, the audience not only sees Pompey's military success but subconsciously recognizes the allusion to previous great leaders. Pompey the Great 's display of the spoils won during his campaign are representative of his own victory and of the previous leaders' victories as well, as the spoils are alluded to within the plays presented.[22] The spoils Pompey parades around are thus compared to the spoils represented within the play, and as a result a comparison is drawn between Pompey and Agamemnon and similarities shine. Erasmo's quote above displays the connection between the two presentations

[20] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 45.
[21] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 46.
[22] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 48.

Pompey provides during his theatre's opening, each aspect explored so far alludes to the greatness of Pompey or Pompey himself as the "new" version of previous great leaders. Pompey enters his theatre, again using material culture to create allusions to the previous great leaders.

Appian, briefly mentioned above, writes about Pompey the Great's entrance to his theatre in his work *Roman History.*[23] Appian was a Greek historian with Roman citizenship, writes with some skepticism about Pompey's self-proclamation as Alexander. "Pompey himself rode in a chariot inlaid with precious stones. He was wearing, it is said, the cloak of Alexander of Macedon...Apparently it was found among the possessions of Mithridates that the people of Cos got from Cleopatra."[24] However skeptical, Appian provides key information to how Pompey utilized the past to allude to himself being a newer version of a great leader and general, one remarkably familiar in the Roman public's eye. Pompey's entrance, a gem covered chariot and adorned with the cloak of Alexander the Great, creating Pompey as Alexander. Again, as mentioned above, Pompey's ownership of the cloak thus creates him as the domineer of Alexander the Great's culture and whoever the previous owner was. Along with Pompey's entrance to the theatre, Pompey had earlier adopted Alexander the Great's *anastole* hairstyle, which provides further evidence of Pompey's presentation as the new Alexander.[25] The two examples above, relating Pompey to Alexander, are representative of an intentional use of the past. In each aspect of Pompey's theatre, Pompey is consistently and continuously self-presenting as previous classical leadership to the Roman people. However, Pompey does not stop

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[23] The exact period in which Appian wrote *Roman History* is debated, but the text was likely recorded between 145-165 AD.

[24] Appian. *Roman History, Volume III.* Edited and translated by Brian McGing. Loeb Classical Library 4. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2019. 385.

[25] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 49.

his self-presentation with Alexander the Great, he continues to Agamemnon. While Pompey mainly utilizes the cloak for his allusion to Alexander, the plays and spectacles allude him further to both Alexander and Agamemnon. "By self-identifying with the triumphing Agamemnon within the dramatic act of the *Clytemnestra,* Pompey establishes a pattern with his earlier self-identification with Alexander at his own triumph. The effect is a double simultaneous allusion to two famous generals who had conquered Asia with whom he inserts himself as the third member of this legendary group."[26] Pompey's utilization of material culture goes further than the alleged cloak of Alexander, the spectacles themselves and each individual aspect serve as material culture used to bolster the very same self-identification that Pompey creates. These spectacles and grandiose acts undoubtedly created a connection between Pompey and the previous leadership he so clearly wanted to be compared to, but this was not met without skepticism.

Appian's skepticism of Pompey's actions within Roman History leaks through his language, but he had not written at the theatre's opening. As Appian was not at the opening of the theatre, so his skepticism of Pompey's use of Alexander's cloak is notable. However, Cicero, a Roman statesman, philosopher, and orator, writes to his friend Marcus Marius describing the spectacles at the Theatre of Pompey through a firsthand account. Both Cicero and Marius served as *quaestors*, which makes their correspondence valuable for understanding the sociopolitical sphere of their time. Cicero's writes about Pompey's opening of his theatre and the plays presented. This letter, as an eyewitness account of the events and a reflection of Pompey's own perspective, provides an essential primary source to understanding how Roman leaders strategically used the past through material culture as well as Roman reactions to these events.

[26] Erasmo, "The Theatre of Pompey: Staging the Self through Roman Architecture." 50.

Cicero provides an eyewitness account of some of the grandiose claims surrounding Pompey's theatre and thus communicates with the other sources surrounding Pompey the Great. Pompey's opinion on his event himself is provided within Cicero's letter to Marius, "Or perhaps, having scorned gladiators, you are sorry not to have seen the athletes! Pompey himself admits that they were a waste of time and midday oil!"[27] Considering Cicero and Pompey had a personal/political relationship, Pompey is seen here through a more vulnerable light; Pompey's opinion here was likely never shared with the Roman people. Their political relationship stemmed from Cicero supporting bills favorable to Pompey and his defense of Pompey's clients in the courtroom throughout his career as well as Pompey being responsible for Cicero's long desired return from exile in 57 B.C.[28] Even with their relationship, Cicero does not shy away from criticism of these grand spectacles. "Anyhow, if these sights are worth seeing, you have seen them often; and we spectators saw nothing new. The last day was for the elephants. The groundlings showed much astonishment thereat, but no enjoyment."[29] Considering the letter is a private primary source, rather than a speech or public work, Cicero is clearly more honest surrounding the spectacles. However, Cicero's letter still gives direct and concise evidence of public reactions to Pompey's spectacles and their existence. "What pleasure is there in getting a *Clytemnestra* with six hundred mules or a *Trojan Horse* with three thousand mixing bowls or a variegated display of calvary and infantry equipment in some battle or other? The public gaped at all this; it would not have amused you at all."[30] The quote above highlights the spectacles and grandiose actions surrounding the opening of the theatre but also provides the public's reaction to those spectacles.

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[27] Cicero. *Letters to Friends, Volume I: Letters 1-113.* Edited and translated by D. R. Shackleton Bailey. Loeb Classical Library 205. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2001. 175.
[28] Williams Jr, Charles. "Pompey and Cicero: An Alliance of Convenience." M.A. Thesis. Texas State University-San Marcos, 2013. 1.
[29] Cicero. *Letters to Friends, Volume I: Letters 1-113.* 175.
[30] Cicero. *Letters to Friends, Volume I: Letters 1-113.* 175.

While the letter does not give individual opinions from the crowd, Cicero's text at least infers that the audience was impressed and influenced by the events. Cicero's correspondence and his speeches give insight into how Romans felt about these events, whether through observation or individual opinions. Richard C. Beacham and Hugh Denard write about these spectacles in an analogous manner, referencing Cicero, in *Living Theatre in the Ancient Roman House.* "He evidently found such spectacle tedious, but undoubtedly it reminded the audience (and was thus intended) of Pompey's memorable triumph exactly six years earlier; the greatest Rome had ever seen."[31] Beacham and Denard thus contextualize Cicero's correspondence and Pompey's purpose to the audience, which was to remind them of his triumph and his self-identification as previous leadership. Cicero's letter in tandem with some of the other primary and secondary sources is essential to understanding through a case study of Pompey the Great, how Roman leaders utilized material culture to gain power, and at times, provide insight into the Roman people's opinions on this subject. Both primary sources provide insight into the sociopolitical sphere of their respective time periods and examples of Roman leaders utilizing the past for their own strategic purposes. This practice, however, did not stop in Ancient Rome or with Pompey the Great, numerous leaders utilized and continued this practice throughout Ancient Rome and Byzantine Empire.

One final object of material culture used was coinage, while Pompey the Great did not mint coins or place his face on coins himself, it was frequently done by his allies and even by his

[31] Beacham, Richard C., and Hugh Denard. "Roman Theatricality and Theatricalism." Chapter. In *Living Theatre in the Ancient Roman House: Theatricalism in the Domestic Sphere*, 1–35. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023. 4.

sons.[32](Figure 2.) The symbolism was indirect, as he did not create these coins himself, but the propaganda and symbolism did sometimes occur during his lifetime. After Pompey was defeated by Caesar, Pompey's sons attempted to utilize coins with their father's face to revitalize his reputation as well as bolster their own.[33] (Figure 3.) Again, each coin represents Pompey the Great's accomplishments but also signifies a relationship with the past. The second coin has characters from the Odyssey as well as Neptune on the opposite side of Pompey's head, both representations of a Greco-Roman past. There is a clear use of representation through coinage and comparison to Gods/previous leaders, even if Pompey himself is not comparing himself to Neptune. It can be speculated that Pompey may have wanted to use coinage to present his triumphs; however, within the Roman Republic this would have been symbolic of a dictatorship or monarchy. These coins were material representations of Pompey's triumphs and Pompey himself, like the captives/spoils in his theatre even if not fashioned by his own accord. The fact still stands that material culture, utilized by Pompey the Great's allies and his sons, represents how material culture *could* be used to propagandize Pompey's greatness. Each coin has features of Pompey himself or are direct portraits of him and depictions of his accomplishments. Even though Pompey the Great himself did not utilize coinage to further consolidate his power, that is untrue for the second leader studied.

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[32] "The British Museum Images." British Museum Images. Accessed April 30, 2025. https://www.bmimages.com/preview.asp?image=00336676001&itemw=4&itemf=0001&itemstep=1&itemx=3.

[33] Roman, Ancient. "Denarius (Coin) Portraying Pompey the Great." The Art Institute of Chicago. Accessed April 30, 2025. https://www.artic.edu/artworks/96048/denarius-coin-portraying-pompey-the-great.

Constantine the Great

Constantine the Great, the founder of the Byzantine empire, with the creation of Constantinople as the new capital, previously Byzantium, continues to utilize material culture and the built environment to build and consolidate power. The Arch of Constantine celebrates Constantine's victory over the Roman Emperor Maxentius, which further solidified his sole role as emperor.[34] (Figure 4.) The statuary/reliefs within the arch and its inscription displays an example of Roman leaders' invocation of the past to further solidify and consolidate themselves as rulers.[35] The arch, commissioned by the Roman senate and the Roman People, contains "ornaments" from other previous monuments, which supports the argument that Roman leaders utilized material culture in a strategic way. "One cannot avoid thinking that this triumphal arch was commissioned by someone who clearly intended to use spolia. The arch, therefore, is not precipitous patchwork but a prominent monument of imperial propaganda by definition."[36] The argument surrounding the intentional use of spolia continues as Beat Brenk (quoted above) writes about the coordination of utilizing spolia. "Such a transference of building materials was by no means inexpensive, let alone practical, since the different heights of the columns (e.g. in the Lateran) had to be adjusted and leveled."[37] Brenk's quote displays more evidence for the intentional use of spolia, which could be argued for Pompey's theatre as well. The transference

[34] Constantine and Maxentius ruled as co-emperors, under a tetrarchy, which the title to emperor was contested and thus ended in civil war and Maxentius' defeat.
[35] The statuary or reliefs referenced is taken from various monuments and is shown numerous times throughout the source, a monument to Diocletian, Hadrian, and others.
[36] Brenk, Beat. "Spolia from Constantine to Charlemagne: Aesthetics versus Ideology." *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 41 (1987): 103–9. https://doi.org/10.2307/1291549. 104-105.
[37] Brenk, "Spolia from Constantine to Charlemagne: Aesthetics versus Ideology."106.

of spolia, in every aspect, was not inexpensive and thus intentionally used for political and social power.

As briefly mentioned above, certain portions of the arch utilize pieces of older monuments to figures like Marcus Aurelius, Trajan, and Hadrian, while other portions of the arch remain debated among scholars.[38] Mark Wilson Jones writes about those reliefs and their origins in his work "Genesis and Mimesis." "The building brought together a formidable array of second hand material, or spolia, notably the columns and some of the finest achievements of Roman sculpture: the panels of the so-called Great Trajanic Frieze in the central passage and on the flanks of the attic; the four pairs of Hadrianic roundels, or tondi, on the main facades; the four pairs of panels on the attic from another arch dedicated to Marcus Aurelius..."[39] Each portion mentioned is representative of the spolia Constantine intentionally used for the arch. C. Brian Rose, an archaeologist at the University of Pennsylvania, argues that they repurposed the spolia from other monuments in order to complete the arch in time for Constantine's *decennalia* while still commemorating his victory over Maxentius. While Rose makes a good point, the point still stands that the spolia was used intentionally and the inscription provides material evidence of Roman leaders' use of the past. As a result of the reliefs, there is a clear intentional use of spolia to display Constantine's new dominance over the past emperors and leaders. "The arch, like all triumphal arches, was a monument of political propaganda. The reused reliefs of former times evoked early Roman tradition. With this monument, as a whole, Constantine placed

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[38] Jarrett A. Lobell is editor in chief at ARCHAEOLOGY. "Features - a Monumental Imperial Biography - Archaeology Magazine - March/April 2022." Archaeology Magazine, August 8, 2024. https://archaeology.org/issues/march-april-2022/features/rome-constantine-arch/.

[39] Jones, Mark Wilson. "Genesis and Mimesis: The Design of the Arch of Constantine in Rome." *Journal of the Society of Architectural Historians* 59, no. 1 (2000): 50–77. https://doi.org/10.2307/991562. 52.

himself in the midst of a venerable line of Roman emperors."[40] Again, Constantine's reuse of previous reliefs imposes his own rule in direct relation, or rather overtaking, of the previous emperors. While there is debate on whether Roman citizens would have recognized the repurposed use of these older ornaments, the evocation would have remained. The inscription along with the arch's design recalls previous Roman greatness, while alluding to Constantine as a similar leader to Augustus. "From a tyrant on one side and from every faction of all on the other side at once, with his army he avenged the republic with just arms."[41] Augustus and Constantine here are one in the same, as both are sole leaders of the Roman Empire, but outwardly restoring or as the arch states "avenging" the republic. Although it does not mention other leaders by name, the inscription still references Rome's past and Constantine's domination of it. The material within the arch and its inscription offers evidence of Roman leadership utilizing the past to consolidate and commemorate their power and success.

The hippodrome of Constantinople was within a triad of buildings and within the city's center, representing Constantine's greatness and the heart of the city itself.[42] Like Pompey's theatre, Constantinople, the Hippodrome, and the statuary inside are representative of the great Roman past. "This then was the city that captured Constantine's imagination: an ancient settlement with a modern face that claimed participation in the traditions and destiny of imperial Rome through the very stuff of its building material."[43] The quote above is directly representative of Constantine's use of statuary, displaying a conscious use of these materials.

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[40] Brenk "Spolia from Constantine to Charlemagne: Aesthetics versus Ideology." 105.
[41] Jarrett A. Lobell is editor in chief at ARCHAEOLOGY. "Features - a Monumental Imperial Biography - Archaeology Magazine - March/April 2022." Archaeology Magazine, August 8, 2024.
[42] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople*. 24.

[43] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople*. 22.

The spaces that these antiquities were kept in are also not done without intent, they were all placed in the "capital's foremost gathering spaces," which consistently and continuously keep Constantine's vision (of a New Rome and of a new Augustus, Alexander the Great, etc.) in the public eye.[44] Paroma Chatterjee bolsters the quote above with a similar one within her text *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture*. "since the Hippodrome was one of the few sites – possibly the only one in the city – to bring together depictions of the emperor's *actual* and *reflected* glory (the latter through images of the greatest charioteers, among others), it evinces the tensions inherent in reconciling the imperial image and its reflection/s in a coherent whole."[45] Chatterjee is again providing more context to the importance of the hippodrome and the antiquities and material culture within. In similar architectural fashion to Pompey the Great's theatre, Constantine rebuilt the Hippodrome of Constantinople. "Among the most splendid of the individual groupings formed during this undertaking was the gathering of antiquities in the Hippodrome. Here monuments stood on bases and honorific columns at the circus entrance, along the *euripus*, in the *cavea*, and above the *carceres*."[46][47] Some of these antiquities were equally as representative of the past as those in Pompey's theatre, or the spectacles held there. While in different physical forms, both leaders utilized material culture and the built environment to (at the very least) attempt to evoke a memory of a past leader. In Constantinople's case, however, the built environment evokes the memory of Rome and presents itself as the "New Rome."[48]

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[44] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople, 37.*
[45] Chatterjee, *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture:* 47.
[46] Bassett, Sarah Guberti. "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 87.

[47] Definitions respectively: A water course ditch, seating area, and stalls or prison.
[48] Bassett, "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 94.

The hippodrome itself plays an imposing and vital role like that of Pompey's theatre, the statuary in the hippodrome is much more significant because of this survey. "Monuments such as the Serpent Column and the Ass and the Keeper could have been seen in a similar light. Although both referred to victory and so were appropriate for the sporting ambience, the specific nature of their reference was, on another level, descriptive of the city."[49] The Serpent Column and the Ass and the Keeper, both statuaries, are representative of the sentiment that effectively creates Constantinople as the "new Rome," and Constantine himself a "new" Diocletian or Augustus. The Ass and the Keeper was brought from Nikopolis, it is argued that it was the same as a figure set up by Augustus to represent his victory at Actium.[50] While the Serpent Column was part of an original victory tripod that the Greek allies erected, dedicated to their victory over the Persians in the battle of Plataea.[51] As shown above, both statues had clear histories of victory and triumph over enemies, Constantine's use of these statues was not done without intent, as Bassett argues below. "What was implied in this visual metaphor was the transferal of power from the old city to the new. Constantinople was, in effect, describing itself as the New Rome."[52] These statues served as constant reminders and imposing physical representations of the very past they came from and in turn, respected. The Serpent Column is the first piece of statuary explored to convey that evocation of the past. "Although the Serpent Column commemorated the victory of the Greeks over the Persians at Plataea, it was more than a monument to the fortuitous outcome of a single battle...For them, the monument celebrated nothing less than the triumph of civilization over barbarism. In the Hippodrome this memory lingers, for by its presence the

[49] Bassett, "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 94.
[50] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople,* 212-213.
[51] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople,* 227.
[52] Bassett, "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 94.

Serpent Column described Constantinople as the new protector of these ancient values."[53] Although the "protector" of these values, Constantine was not only using the statuary to allude to the past, through the removal and transfer to Constantinople he asserts dominance over the past traditions. "Like Septimius Severus before him, Constantine created a city that downplayed indigenous Greek tradition in favor of the overarching magnificence of Rome, its empire, and its institutions."[54] These antiquities allude to Constantine as the protector/domineer of these values and compare him to previous Roman leaders (or Constantinople as the New Rome,) just as Pompey's theatrics did to Alexander the Great and Agamemnon. These allusions or comparisons are twofold for Constantine, as in Constantine himself along with Constantinople itself, are the "new" versions of that respected and chimerical past. This relationship of allusion continues with the Ass and the Keeper within the Hippodrome as well. "The Ass and the Keeper can also be understood as a reference to Constantinopolitan primacy. In its initial setting the monument glorified Augustus, his victory, the consolidation of his power, and the initiation of the principate."[55] The presence of the Ass and the Keeper alludes to the acts of Augustus, but Augustus himself. This allusion, of course, carries onto Constantine's victory and the consolidation of his own power and thus evokes memories of Augustus when thinking of Constantine or Constantinople. The simple fact of moving the statuary from its original site displays the fact that Constantine and Constantinople are in fact the "New" versions of the past that they are attempting to be.

As mentioned before, Constantine is the domineer of the previous owner and intentionally uses the past to show his own personal dominance and create allusions to past

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[53] Bassett, "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 94.
[54] Bassett, . *The urban image of late antique Constantinople,* 22.
[55] Bassett, "The Antiquities in the Hippodrome of Constantinople." 94-95.

leaders. These aspects of allusion did not stop with statuary; the city and spaces were adorned with imagery too. "In addition to apotropaia and victory monuments, the Hippodrome was stocked with images of public figures. These monuments included overtly imperial images of the Emperors Augustus and Diocletian and a probable representation of the dictator Julius Caesar."[56] This imagery in the Hippodrome relates to the imagery and reuse of reliefs in the Arch of Constantine, as they represent both the safekeeping and domineering of previous leadership and culture. One final quote from Chatterjee's text further solidifies Constantine's actions and works surrounding the Hippodrome. Constantine, "completed the Hippodrome, adorning it with works in bronze and with every excellence.... And he also built a Forum which was large and exceedingly fine; and he set in the middle a great porphyry column of Theban stone, worthy of admiration, and he set on top of the same column a great statue of himself with rays of light on his head, a work in bronze which he had brought from Phrygia."[57] Chatterjee's quote above not only represents the Hippodrome, but the relevance of statuary during Constantine's reign and the intentional creation of such a statue. The statue of Constantine alludes to him as dominating Thebes, as he is sitting above their column and using the Phrygian work which serves the same purpose. Constantine's intentional use of material culture and domineering of the past did not stop with the Hippodrome, it continued to the Arch of Constantine.

As with Pompey the Great, Constantine had primary sources that corroborated statuary in the Hippodrome and Constantine's intentional use, or destruction, of opposing people or material culture. The *Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai*, often understood or referred to as a tourist guide to Constantinople, is an important source to understanding contemporary views of Constantine and

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[56] Bassett, *The urban image of late antique Constantinople,* 63-64.
[57] Chatterjee, Paroma. *Between the Pagan Past and Christian Present in Byzantine Visual Culture.* 92.

the statuary within Constantinople.[58] While the text was written after Constantine's death, it writes about actions and places where the statuary stood at the time, often giving credit to Constantine for erecting the different sorts of material culture. One of the strengths of the *Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai* is the representation of ancient sculpture, which bolsters the argument surrounding Constantine's use of the past. One section notes Constantine's destruction of statuary, which is representative of Constantine's dominance of not only the past, but other cultures. Both are aforementioned in the text, but having the *Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai* is useful to providing more evidence of his intentional erection or other forms of dominance. "And there the war of Constantine and Severus took place, and [he] defeated Herculius and hung up his head and those of his leaders in the vaults for seven days. And after this he broke in pieces the pagan idols (*eidola)* and left them for display...A statue (*stele)* of Constantine was fashioned there up above the vault in the upper part, holding the sign of the cross in the right hand."[59] Constantine's destruction of the pagan idols and erection of his own statue is an example of material culture representing the dominance of Constantine over the previous leader and culture. Even if the statue's erection was not ordered by Constantine himself, the destruction of the previous statuary/material culture is representative of his intent through the destruction and displays his dominance.

Another one of the notes or stories within the text covers Constantine's intentional use of statuary and covers the use of material culture in the Hippodrome and Forum, both provide

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[58] The literal translation is "brief historical notes," however, the understood version above highlights the text's purpose.

[59] "Constantinople in the Early Eighth Century: The Parastaseis Syntomoi Chronikai : Introduction, Translation, and Commentary: Free Download, Borrow, and Streaming." Internet Archive, January 1, 1984. https://archive.org/details/constantinoplein0000unse. 133-135.

evidence to Constantine as the "new Augustus," and Constantinople as the "New Rome." "Constantine set up many statues (*stelai*) in the forum, among which up to thirty were of his own commissioning."[60] While the specific statuary is not mentioned, the text consistently highlights the importance and intentional use of statuary within Constantinople, specifically surrounding Constantine, and his efforts. These efforts are again reflected in the Hippodrome. "The hyena above the dragon statue (*drakontaion*) came from Antioch first to Constantinople in the reign of Constantine the Great."[61] The statuary here comes from Antioch, again representative of the importance of statuary as an allusion to Constantine's domination of other cultures, cities, and leaders. This is displayed multiple times within the text itself; however, Constantine's dominance is displayed in separate ways. "In the Hippodrome statues (*eidola*) were set up which came from Rome, as many as sixty, among which was the likeness (*homoioma*) of Augustus, as is told, but not written down."[62] The statuary in the Hippodrome is representative of Rome as it is directly from Rome. Constantine (and Constantinople,) are effectively the new Augustus and the New Rome as a product of this. Both Constantine and the city itself are acting as domineers of the ancient capital of Rome as they are the caretakers and the domineers of the previous statuary and in turn the previous culture. Again, while the text is unfortunately not written during Constantine's reign, it is not so far removed from the stories it tells. The *Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai* provides insight into how Constantine himself utilized statuary and material culture to assert his dominance over the past as well as over other contemporary leaders and cultures. As a result, Constantine continues to allude to himself as the new Augustus and Constantinople as the

[60] *Constantinople in the early eighth century: the Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai,* 137.
[61] *Constantinople in the early eighth century: the Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai,* 141.
[62] *Constantinople in the early eighth century: the Parastaseis syntomoi chronikai,* 137.

New Rome. Constantine the Great did not stop the use of material culture at statuary; he also frequently used coins to consolidate his power and compare himself to previous leaders.

Constantine the Great's use of coinage was more direct than Pompey the Great, as he was the sole emperor. Constantine the Great consistently represented himself and his accomplishments on coinage and it was a powerful, daily tool that citizens would have used. The coins are a consistent representation of Constantine/his accomplishments and would have been recognizable by Roman citizens. One coin shows Constantine the Great's portrait, but on the other side it has a more meaningful dedication to Constantine's vision of himself as pious and grand.[63] (Figure 5) The labarum of Constantine, represented on the opposite side of the coin, was a constant display of victory. "The back shows a labarum, the special military standard that was made for the army after Constantine's vision, with the chi (X) rho (P) symbol on top, a symbol invented by Constantine to stand for Christ. The bottom of the labarum is piercing a snake, an animal with deep meaning in the Judeo-Christian tradition."[64] The coin itself was a constant reminder of Constantine's power and accomplishments; this coin was something that people would have used daily and like our coinage today.

Another coin that represents Constantine the Great's power and use of the past is where he is shown looking toward the heavens. (Figure 6.) However, Constantine looking toward the heavens was not his own invention, as it was commonly used in Greek coinage to represent

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[63] "Coin Minted by Constantine." Coin minted by Constantine | World History Commons. Accessed April 30, 2025. https://worldhistorycommons.org/coin-minted-constantine#:~:text=This%20is%20a%20copper%20alloy,in%20depictions%20of%20Roman%20emperors.

[64] "Coin Minted by Constantine." World History Commons.

looking to the Gods or having an affinity with them.[65] Again, the example above allows citizens to recognize Constantine the Great daily and display his own connection to the Greco-Roman past. One final example of how coinage was utilized to consolidate power and represent leaders' greatness was a posthumous coin minted by Constantine's sons, like Pompey the Great's sons. This posthumous coin showed Constantine the Great being lifted from a chariot into heaven by God's hand. "What is interesting is the obverse part of the legend starts with the initials DV, which is short for DIVO. This proclaims that Constantine was deified, becoming a god himself."[66] (Figure 7) While this was after Constantine's death, the coin obviously has a significant impact on people's understanding of Constantine. The coin itself being within the average citizen's hand daily, would have been a consistent reminder of Constantine the Great's accomplishments, of himself, and of a deified version of himself. Material culture within the lens of coinage represents an accessible and ordinary form of material culture that served as constant reminders of not only the leaders themselves, but their accomplishments as well. While reminders of the leaders and their accomplishments are an important aspect of these daily used forms of material culture, they also signify Roman leaders' direct connection to the past.

Conclusion

The use of history and material culture was not simply a means of self-promotion and preservation for Roman leaders; it was the foundation of their power and influence. As these leaders erected, funded, or destroyed portions of material culture, their political and social power grew and bolstered. By using past figures and cities to shape their own identities, they heightened their authority. The use of the past was to display and continually assert dominance.

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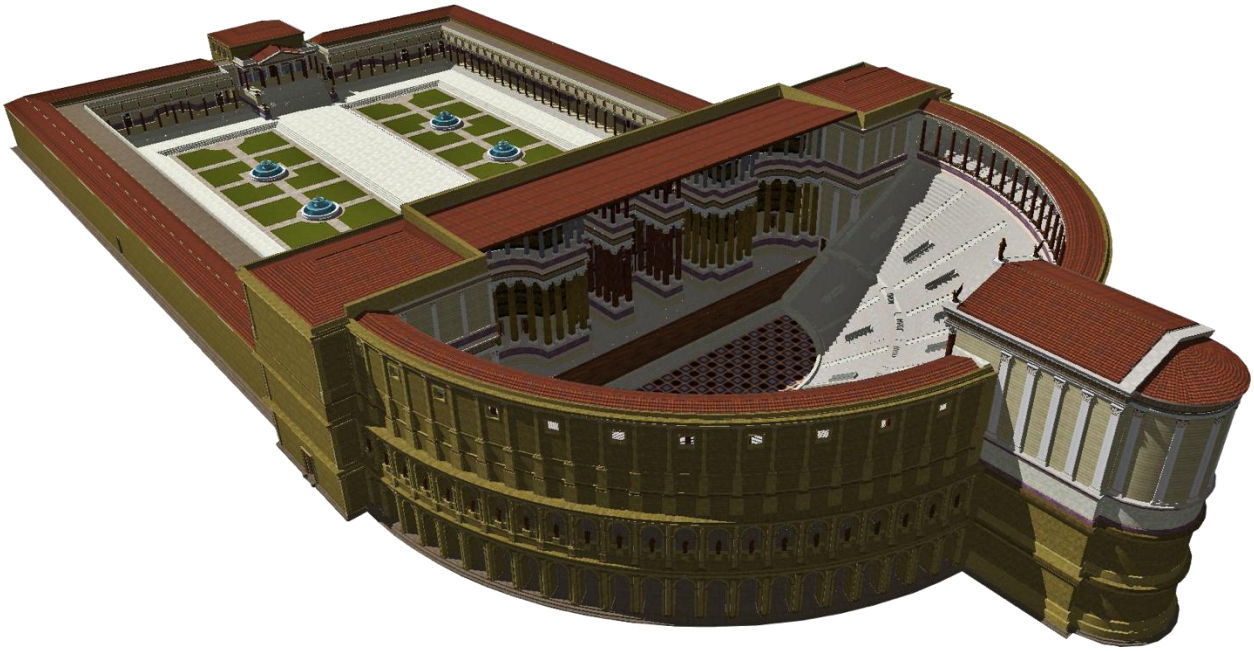
[65]Clark, Victor. "Constantine the Great: The Coins Speak," M.A. Thesis, Middle Tennessee State University. 13.
[66] Clark, "Constantine the Great: The Coins Speak," 24.

This dominance was sometimes continued after their deaths to portray their own sons as worthy of the same power they once held, or even to deify them after death. The intentional and specific practice of using material culture and statuary intertwined with history as seen through Pompey the Great and Constantine the Great, displays a practice that is still used and held close by contemporary political leaders today.

(Figure 1) a 3D reconstruction of the Theatre of Pompey.



(Figure 2) Coin depicting Pompey the Great and ship on coin's opposite side, likely depicting Pompey's successful campaign in Spain.

(Figure 3) Coin portraying Pompey the Great on one side and Anapius and Amphinomus carrying their parents on other side. Neptune is between them, standing on a ship prow.

(Figure 4) The Arch of Constantine is represented below.

(Figure 5) Coin minted by Constantine the Great

(Figure 6) Coin depicting Constantine the Great looking toward heaven.

(Figure 7) Coin depicting Constantine's portrait on one side. Other side depicts God reaching down to Constantine from heaven.

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